

Table Aid

What it does, how to use it, and how to build one from your own notes

One HTML file. No install, no account, no internet.

D&D 2024 rules. You roll the dice; it does the arithmetic.

Your campaign stays on your machine. Save writes a file. That is the whole system.

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 What this is | 11 Setting Claude up — once |
| 2 Five minutes to your first fight | 12 From your notes to the tracker |
| 3 The header | 13 Checking Claude's work |
| 4 Initiative | 14 Asking for changes |
| 5 Party | 15 Saving, undo and backups |
| 6 Bestiary | 16 Keyboard |
| 7 Encounters | 17 Things that will bite you |
| 8 Story | A Map tiles |
| 9 Tools | B Editor syntax |
| 10 The players' screen | |

Unofficial fan tool. Not affiliated with Wizards of the Coast.

Every screenshot is taken from the demonstration file, *The Miller's Debt*.

1. WHAT THIS IS

Table Aid is a Dungeon Master's screen that lives in one browser tab.

It is a **single HTML file**. There is no installer, no account, no server and no internet connection involved. You open it, it works. **Save** writes one JSON file to your disk holding your entire session; **Load** brings it back. Your campaign never leaves your machine, which means nobody can lose it, sell it, or take it offline.

It assumes you are running **D&D 2024 rules**, that you roll physical dice at the table, and that the laptop is open in front of you while four people wait. Every decision in it comes from that: the fight screen is dense because you scan it, the arithmetic is automatic because you shouldn't be doing it in your head, and the tool never rolls anything unless you press a button that says roll.

There are two ways to fill it in. You can type everything yourself — every tab has an editor and nothing is locked. Or you can write your adventure as plain text, hand it to Claude with the build spec, and paste back what it gives you. That second route is covered in §11, including the part that matters most: **everything Claude invents is marked in red until you say otherwise**.

The demonstration file. *The Miller's Debt* is a complete two-hour oneshot for four level-3 characters, built into a copy of the tracker so you can press things without breaking anything of your own. Every screenshot in this manual is taken from it.

2. FIVE MINUTES TO YOUR FIRST FIGHT

If you want to see it working before you build anything, open **the demonstration file** — *The Miller's Debt*, a complete two-hour oneshot. It opens on a panel explaining what you are looking at and what to press first.

To start your own from scratch:

1. **⋮ top right** — name the campaign, set party size and level. Everything that calculates difficulty reads those two numbers.
2. **Party** — + *Add character* once per player. Click an HP bar to roll hit points per level.
3. **Bestiary** — + *New creature* opens a library of 118 templates that rescale to any challenge rating. Pick something, set the CR, edit the name.
4. **Encounters** — + *New encounter*, add creatures from the dropdown, and watch the difficulty bar rate the fight against your actual party.
5. **Load into initiative**, and play.
6. **Save** before you close the tab. There is no autosave — see §12.

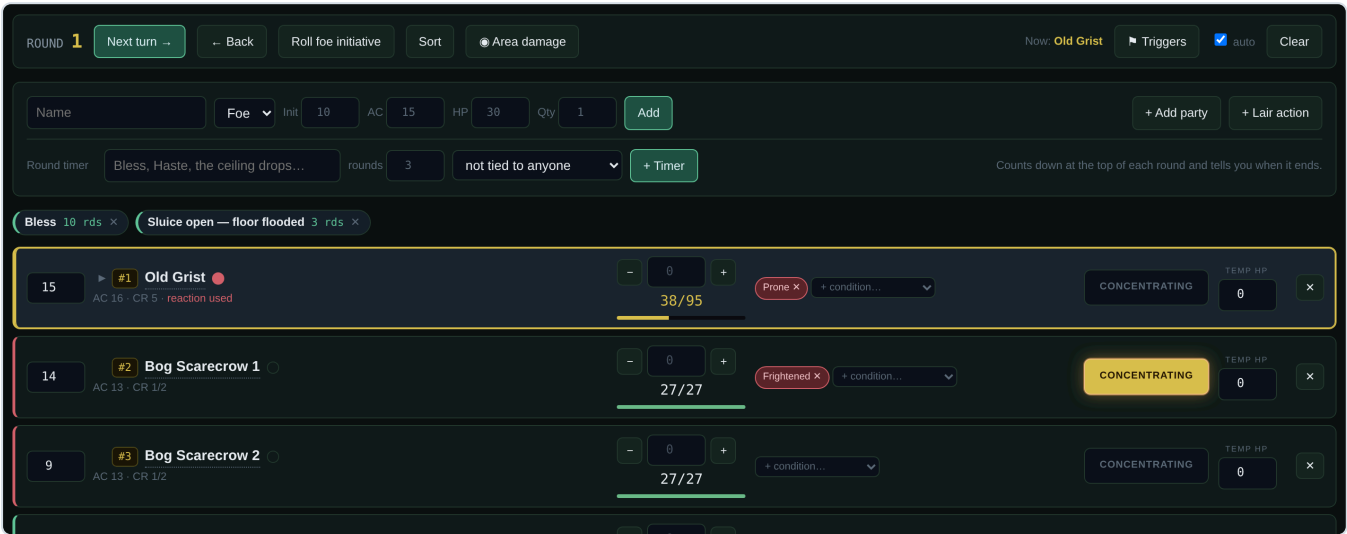
3. THE HEADER

Always visible, on every tab.

CONTROL	WHAT IT DOES
Campaign name	Set in options. The badge under it shows party level and size.
Session clock	Start, pause, ±5 minute nudges, and click the readout to type a time . Accepts , meaning two hours fifteen, or a bare meaning ninety minutes.
Dice	The floating quick-roller. The R key does the same.
↶ Undo	Steps back through the last twenty actions. Ctrl+Z anywhere.
Save / Load	One JSON file holds everything.
The pill	How long since you last saved. Green, then amber at five minutes, then red at fifteen.
Players	Opens and closes the second window for the other screen (§10).
N to review	How many things Claude added that you haven't looked at yet (§11).
	Dark, light, or follow the system.
	Options: name, party, theme, background image, who rolls the dice , backups, the review walk, and the paste-a-build box.

4. INITIATIVE

The only screen that should be open during a fight. Everything on it is fed by the other tabs.



The fight screen: round timers across the top, table numbers beside each foe, a reaction dot, and the active turn ringed in amber.

The row

Each combatant is one row, colour-coded down the left edge: **teal for player characters, green for allies, red for foes**. The active turn is ringed in amber. Anything at 0 hit points fades out.

- **Initiative** on the left is editable — type over it and press Tab.
- **The name**, with a ► in front of it if that creature has spells or limited-use abilities.

- **The meta line** underneath carries everything low-priority as plain text rather than more buttons: AC, challenge rating, temporary hit points, legendary counters, spent reaction, and any round timer attached to that creature.
- **Damage** goes in the small box between – and +. Type a number and press **Enter** to damage, **Shift+Enter** to heal. Focus stays in the box, so you can keep typing.
- **Conditions** are chips. Add one from the dropdown, click a chip to remove it, and **hover any chip to read what the condition actually does** and what saves against it.
- **CONCENTRATING** is a toggle, and it is deliberately large, because it is the thing most often forgotten.
- **TEMP HP** is separate from hit points and is eaten first by any damage.

Table numbers

Every foe carries **#1, #2, #3** in the order it entered the fight, in an amber chip beside its name. This exists because the miniatures on your table are whatever was in the box and rarely match the stat block. Put the matching numbered die next to each model and the screen tells you which is which.

Click the number to change it. **Numbers are never recycled** when something dies or is removed — the die on the table doesn't move, so neither does the number. Loading a fresh encounter starts again at 1, because all the foes are replaced.

The reaction dot

The small circle beside each name. Click it when that creature spends its reaction; it turns red and the meta line says so. It **clears itself automatically at the start of that creature's next turn**, which is exactly when a reaction comes back.

Round timers

Type a name and a number of rounds into the bar above the list. The timer appears as a chip, **counts down at the top of each round**, and announces itself the round it ends. Tie it to a creature and it also shows on that creature's row. Use it for Bless, Haste, a burning building, or anything with a clock on it.

Area damage

● **Area damage**, or the **A** key. One pass over every combatant: tick who is in the blast, mark each as *failed / saved / no effect*, type the damage once, and it applies full, half or nothing to each, eats temporary hit points first, and **queues a concentration check for every concentrating creature that took damage** so they arrive one at a time instead of being forgotten.

Area damage

Tick who is in it, mark who saved, and it applies the right amount to each in one go. Temporary hit points are eaten first, and every concentrating creature that takes damage queues up a check.

THE EFFECT

DAMAGE ROLLED

22



A SUCCESSFUL SAVE HALVES IT (UNTICK FOR SAVE-FOR-NONE)

All foes

All PCs

Everyone

None

3 creatures · 55 total damage



#3

Bog Scarecrow 2 AC 13 · 11/27 · conc

-22

failed

saved

no effect



#1

Old Grist AC 16 · 95/95

-11

failed

saved

no effect



#2

Bog Scarecrow 1 AC 13 · 27/27

-22

failed

saved

no effect



Bram Ashdown AC 18 · 30/30

—

failed

saved

no effect



Ivy Quill AC 12 · 16/16

—

failed

saved

no effect



Doric Vane AC 18 · 23/23

—

failed

saved

no effect



Sable AC 15 · 23/23

—

failed

saved

no effect

Cancel

Apply damage

Area damage: one damage number, one pass, and it does the arithmetic for everybody.

Concentration

When a creature flagged CONCENTRATING takes damage, a check opens by itself. It shows the damage, the DC — $\max(10, \text{damage} \div 2)$ — and what you need to roll. It says **roll a die**, you roll your own and type the number, and it adds that creature's stored Constitution save and tells you whether concentration holds. Dropping to 0 hit points ends it with no save, automatically.

If your table would rather the screen rolled, turn on $\vdots \rightarrow$ **Dice** $\rightarrow$ **let the tracker roll the dice** and a **Roll d20** button appears beside the box. See §9.

Automatic triggers

Things that fire at a fixed moment — regeneration, an aura that applies before initiative, a recharge, "they're already singing when the party walks in" — pop up at the right time rather than depending on your memory.

Start of combat



Everything that fires before the first turn.

They are not moving yet

REMEMBER

Bog Scarecrow

All four stand exactly where the field says they should. Nothing happens until someone touches the fence line, crosses the ditch, or attacks. Let the players decide to start this fight.

got it

She starts under the water

REMEMBER

Old Grist

Nobody sees her until she acts. Roll her initiative but do not put a model down until her first turn — she comes up out of the race behind whoever is nearest the wheel.

got it

The sluice lever is on the north wall

REMEMBER

Old Grist

A DC 13 Strength (Athletics) check closes the gate. That switches off her regeneration for good. Wick knows where the lever is and will point at it if anyone asks him.

got it

Roll initiative for the foes

ROLL

Use the Roll foe initiative button, then Sort. PCs enter their own numbers.

got it

Done

Start-of-combat triggers fire the moment an encounter loads.

Start-of-combat triggers fire when an encounter loads. Start-of-turn triggers fire on that creature's turn, and anything with a healing amount attached gets an **Apply** button. The **auto** tick in the bar turns the automatic popping off; **Triggers** shows the current turn's on demand.

Lair actions

+ **Lair action** drops a slim row into the order at initiative 20 with a text field. Type what the lair does and it comes round at the right point every round like anything else.

The tray

The ► in front of a name opens that creature's spells and abilities, in a fixed order:

1. **Spell slots** as pips — click to spend, click a spent one to give it back.
2. **Spells**, each with its level, casting time, a one-line effect, and a **cast** button that spends the slot and tells you how many are left.
3. **Legendary resistances and legendary actions** as pips, with a **refill** button and that creature's legendary action menu written out underneath. Legendary actions refill automatically at the top of each round.
4. **Limited uses** — anything finite, including recharge abilities with a **roll d6** button.

5. PARTY

One card per player character. This is not a character sheet; it is the six things that change during a session and that you, not the player, tend to be asked about.

The screenshot shows four character cards in a dark-themed interface. Each card has a title, level, class, and various stats and abilities.

- Bram Ashdown** (LV 3, Fighter 3 - Battle Master): AC 18, HP 30, Max 30, Temp 0. Spell slots: 1 (4/4), 2 (2/2). Limited-use abilities: Second Wind, Action Surge, Superiority dice (d8).
- Ivy Quill** (LV 3, Wizard 3 - Evocation): AC 12, HP 16, Max 16, Temp 0. Spell slots: 1 (4/4), 2 (2/2). Limited-use abilities: Arcane Recovery, Sculpt Spells.
- Doric Vane** (LV 3, Cleric 3 - Life): AC 18, HP 23, Max 23, Temp 0. Spell slots: 1 (4/4), 2 (2/2). Limited-use abilities: Channel Divinity, Preserve Life.
- Sable** (LV 3, Rogue 3 - Thief): AC 15, HP 23, Max 23, Temp 0. Spell slots: 1 (4/4), 2 (2/2). Limited-use abilities: Sneak Attack 2d6 — once per turn, Fast Hands (bonus action).

The party tab. Hit points, spell slots as pips, ability uses, conditions and death saves.

Hit points with temporary hit points, spell slots as clickable pips, class features with uses, conditions, and death saves. **Short rest** clears per-rest features; **long rest** clears everything and restores hit points.

The hit point roller

Click any HP bar. This table rolls hit points per level, so the roller does it properly.

Bram Ashdown — HP roll sheet

×

Roll each level as you levelled. Level 1 takes the maximum die result by the rules.

Hit die

d10

CON mod

3

Levels

3

Bonus / level

0

Flat bonus

0

☒ Level 1 is max

Roll all empty

Reroll everything

Fill with average

Clear

LEVEL	ROLL		CON	BONUS	GAINED	RUNNING
Lv 1 (max)	10		+3	—	13	13
Lv 2	6	d10	+3	—	9	22
Lv 3	5	d10	+3	—	8	30

TOTAL MAXIMUM HP

30

Average for this build would be 31 — you're 1 down

Minimum 1 HP gained per level is applied automatically.

Set max only

Set max & heal to full

The HP roller: one row per level, level one maxed, a running total, and how far off the average you landed.

One row per level, level 1 taking the maximum die by default, a per-row roll button, and bulk actions — roll all empty, reroll everything, take the average, clear. Set the hit die and the Constitution modifier at the top, and add a per-level bonus if a feat is giving you one. It applies the **minimum 1 hit point per level** rule, keeps a running total, and tells you how far above or below the average build you landed. The number of filled rows sets the character's level, which is shown on the card.

6. BESTIARY

Every creature in the campaign. **Foes get red cards, allies and NPCs get green ones**, and the tracker treats the two differently everywhere — including on the battle maps and in area damage.

Old GristFOECR 5 · 1,800 XPThe Mill

1+ Initiative

Large Fey, Neutral Evil

AC 16HP 95 (10d10+40)Speed 30 ft., swim 40 ft.

STR18 (+4)

DEX14 (+2)

CON18 (+4)

INT13 (+1)

WIS15 (+2)

CHA12 (+1)

Saves

Con +7, Wis +5 · Skills Deception +4, Perception +5 · PP 15

Millstone Grip

A creature hit by Grind is Grappled (escape DC 15). She can only hold one at a time, and she holds it **under the water**.

Legendary Resistance (2/Day)

When she fails a save, she may choose to succeed instead.

Multiattack

One Grind and one Fen Chill.

Grind

+7, reach 10 ft, 2d8+4 bludgeoning.

Fen Chill

+7, reach 5 ft, 2d6+4 cold, and the target's speed drops 10 ft until the end of its next turn.

Legendary Actions (3/turn)

Wade — move half speed through water without provoking. **Stuice** (costs 2) — the wheel surges: every creature in the water makes a DC 15 Strength save or is moved 15 ft along the race. **Whisper** — she says one true thing about a character in their own parent's voice; DC 13 Wisdom save or Frightened of her until the end of their next turn.

Spellcasting

Save DC 14. Slots: 1st ×3 · 2nd ×2.

Ray of Frost

cantrip — Ranged attack &mdot; 60 ft

Cold damage and the target slows by 10 ft.

Fog Cloud

1st — Concentration &mdot; 20-ft sphere

Heavy obscurement. She uses it to take someone out of sight and drown them quietly.

Hold Person

2nd — Concentration &mdot; Wis save

One humanoid is Paralyzed while she concentrates, with a save at the end of each of its turns.

Misty Step

2nd — Bonus action &mdot; 2/day

She blinks 30 ft to a space she can see. Always back into the water.

A stat block card, with spells and abilities underneath.

Filter by name or group, or narrow to just foes or just allies. + **Initiative** on any card drops it straight into the fight. The ... menu on every card gives Edit, Duplicate, Move up, Move down and Delete — and Delete always asks twice.

The template library

+ **New creature** opens **118 templates in 15 categories** — rabble, soldiers, monsters, beasts, undead, dragons, giants, fiends, fey and celestials, aberrations, elementals and constructs, oozes and plants, casters, leaders and allies.

Pick a target challenge rating and the template is **rebuilt against it**: armour class, hit points, hit dice, attack bonus, save DC and damage all rescale, and bigger creatures gain extra attacks so the dice stay readable rather than turning into **19d8**. **Hover a card to read the finished block before you commit to it.**

Each template also carries the **CR band where it still reads as itself**. Push a kobold to CR 20 or a dragon down to CR 2 and it will tell you that you have left the archetype rather than silently obeying. Nothing is prevented; you are simply told.

Every field in the editor has a **library** button beside it that opens a picker of common entries — 44 traits, 76 spells, standard uses and triggers — with a syntax guide for that specific field. Clicking one appends it rather than replacing what you have already written.

7. ENCOUNTERS

A preset fight that loads into initiative in one click, rated live against your actual party.

PARTY MAGIC ITEMSCommon 0Uncommon 0Rare 0Very rare 0Legendary 0Artifact 0No items counted — budgets are the raw 2024 values.

The scarecrow field

▶ Map⌘ To playersLoad into initiative⋮

Ashfen · the drowned barley, dusk

4× Bog Scarecrow

2× Fen Hound

800 XP · Low-Moderate

Low 0.6k · Mod 0.9k · High 1.6k

They do not move until the party gives them a reason. Fire is the answer and the field is soaked — let someone try anyway. The ditch is chest-deep water; anyone who ends a turn in it starts the Damp clock.

Added by Claude

Guessed the map from 'the mill yard, the pond on one side, a cart to hide behind' — the stairs, the well and the exact layout are mine.

✓ That's fine

The difficulty bar takes the colour of the band the fight lands in.

Table Aid — manual

9

How the difficulty is worked out

The 2024 Dungeon Master's Guide gives an XP budget **per character** at each level. The tracker multiplies that by your party size. **There is no encounter multiplier in the 2024 rules** — the number of monsters does not inflate the budget the way it did in 2014.

For four characters at level 3, that is **Low 600 • Moderate 900 • High 1,600 XP**.

These budgets are tighter than the 2014 ones, so fights that felt "medium" under the old maths often rate above High here. That is the new table, not a fault in the tool.

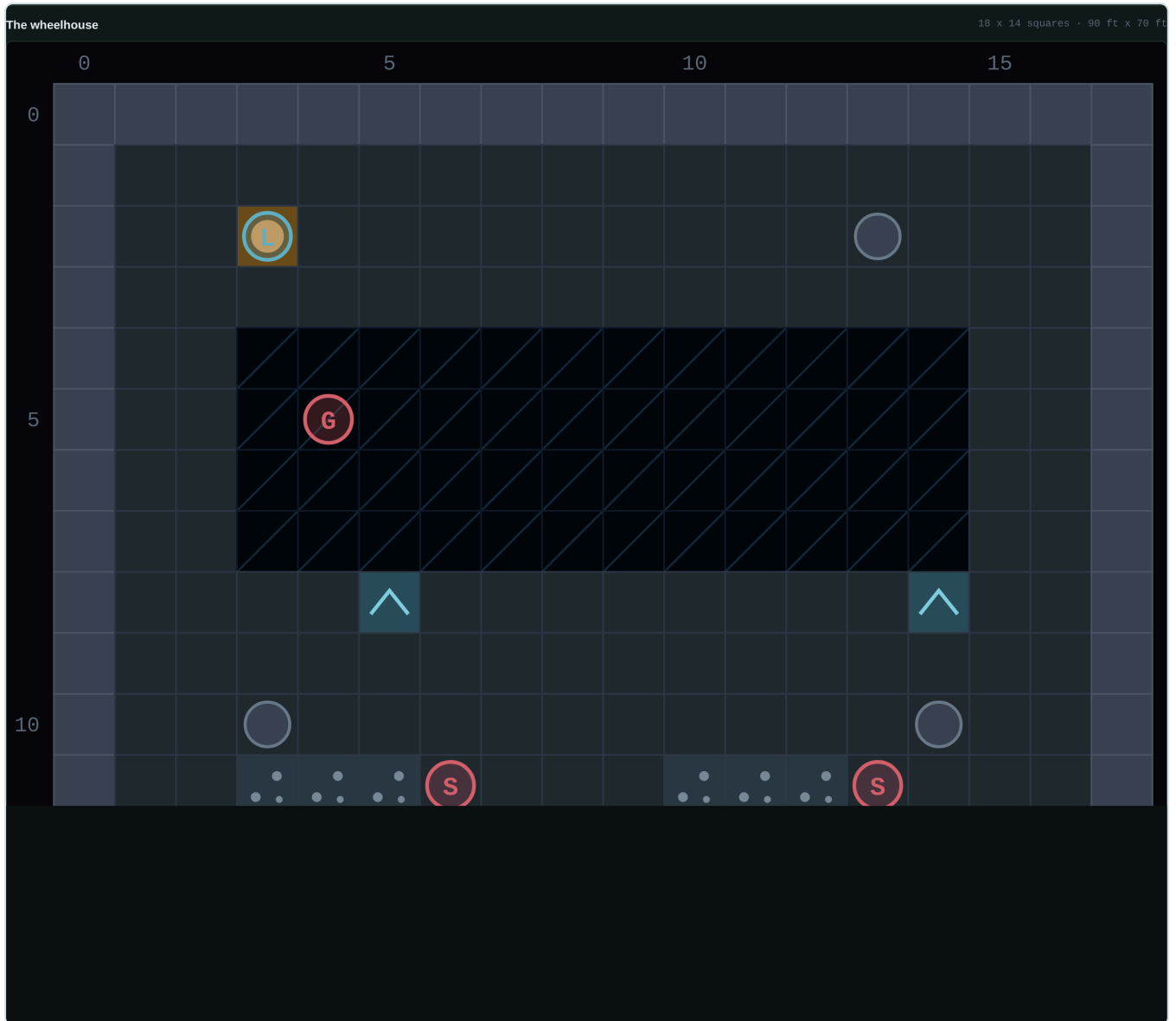
The bar takes **the colour of the band the fight lands in** — blue below Low, green at Moderate, amber, and red at High and above — so you read the band at a glance rather than measuring a position.

Magic items widen the budget. There is no official rule converting gear into encounter XP, so this is homebrew and it is editable: each item adds a percentage to every threshold (common 2%, uncommon 5%, rare 10%, very rare 18%, legendary 30%, artifact 50%), capped at +200%. Count your party's items in the row above the encounters, or set every percentage to zero in  options to switch the feature off entirely.

XP is entered per creature, not per encounter. Put the single-creature value on the stat block and set the quantity in the fight.

Battle maps

Every encounter can carry a schematic map on a 5-foot grid, with a scale line and a note on how to draw it on your own mat.



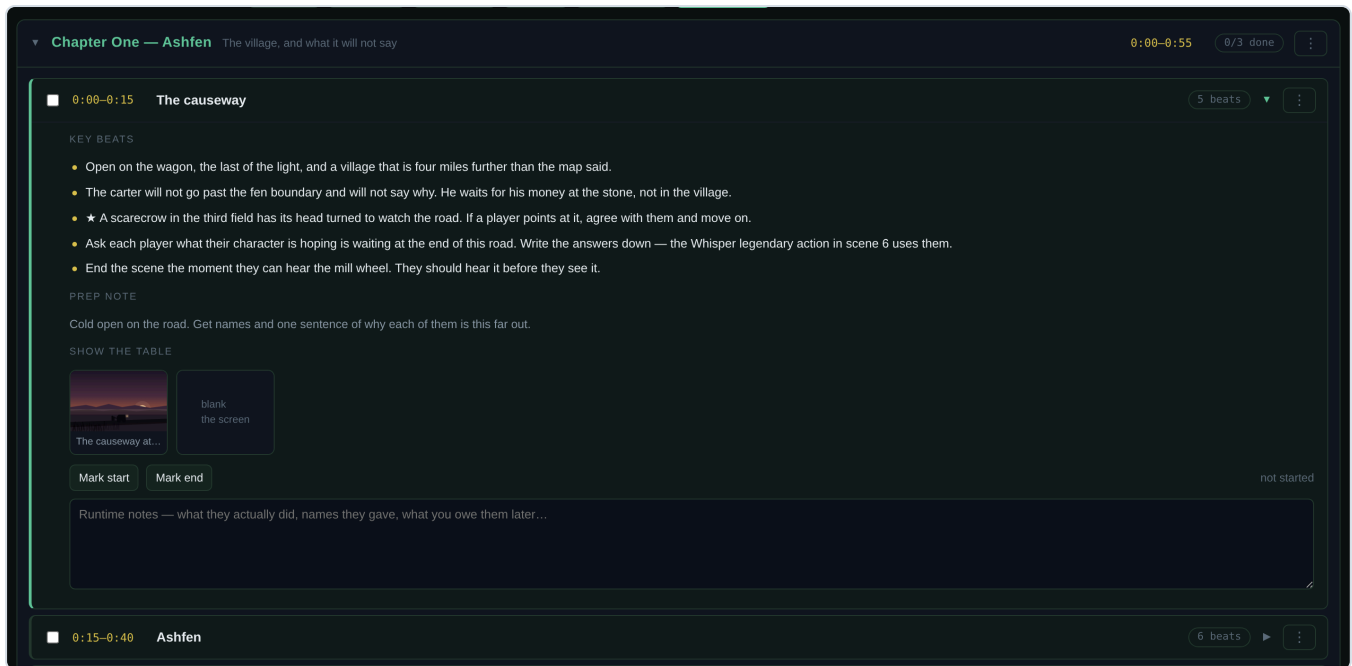
A battle map: the millrace across the middle, stairs crossing it, and the sluice lever on the plinth.

Maps are written as a text grid in the encounter editor — one character per square. The tile language is in Appendix A. **Every row must be the same length**; short rows get padded with floor. Tokens are placed by coordinate and carry a letter, a side and a label.

☑ **To players** puts the map on the second screen (§10).

8. STORY

The running order, and the tab you actually read from during the session.



A segment open: key beats, the prep note, and the images you can throw onto the players' screen.

Chapters

Segments live inside chapters, so a long campaign can fold away everything it has already played. A oneshot needs one chapter. A campaign gets one per session, or one per act.

Click a chapter header to fold it. **Fold finished** collapses every chapter you have fully ticked off. The  on a chapter renames, duplicates, reorders or deletes it — and deleting a chapter moves its segments into the neighbouring one rather than throwing them away. Move a segment up or down past a chapter boundary and it changes chapter.

Key beats

The bullets at the top of an open segment. **This is the most valuable thing in the file.** They are what you read in three seconds while four people look at you: what happens, who they talk to, the decision they face, the line you have to remember to say, the thing you are planting now that pays off in two hours. Lead the pivotal ones with ★. The segment header shows a beat count, so you can see at a glance which scenes you have actually prepped.

Under them sits the **prep note** — the one line you need in your hand — and under that, a **runtime notes** box you type into during play. That box is saved with everything else, and it is what the recap export reads.

Images

Open a segment's editor and there is an *Images for the players' screen* section. Paste links or upload files, name them, reorder them. They appear as thumbnails under **Show the table** in the open segment, and one click throws one onto the player window. There is a *blank the screen* tile next to them for when you want their eyes back on you.

Uploaded images are downscaled to 1600px and stored inside the save file. A handful per scene is fine; forty across a session will make the JSON large. Links cost nothing but need the machine online when you show them.

The fight in this segment

A segment can carry an encounter. Pick one in the segment editor and a  **Run** button appears on the segment, so you start the fight from the story rather than switching tabs and hunting for it.

The clock and the pacing readout

Start the session clock in the header and the Story tab tells you **which segment you should be in right now** and how many you are ahead or behind. **Mark start** and **Mark end** stamp what a scene actually took, which is how you find out that your forty-minute dungeon is a ninety-minute dungeon.

↓ Story PDF

Prints the whole adventure as a document you can read away from the screen: every chapter, every segment with its beats and prep note, the fight that belongs to each, then the handouts with their solutions, the campaign mechanics, and every stat block. Anything still marked as added by Claude is flagged in red in the text.

It uses your browser's own print dialog, so pick the PDF destination rather than a printer — **Save as PDF** in Chrome and Edge, **Save to PDF** in Firefox. This is the single most useful thing to have in front of you the day before a session, and it is also the easiest thing to mark up when you want changes made (§14).

↓ Recap

Writes the session out as a markdown file: chapters, segments, what time each actually ran, the notes you typed during play, and where the party ended. This is the thing to paste into your session log.

9. TOOLS

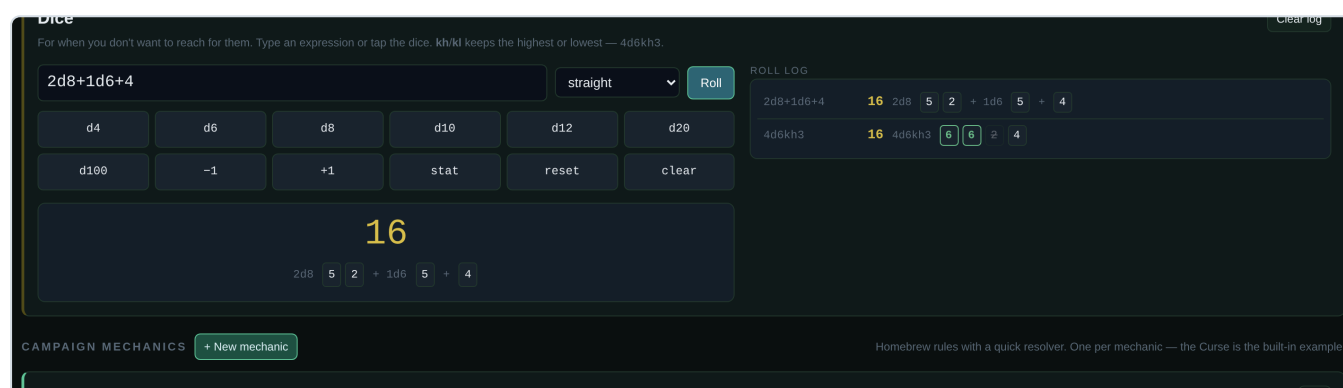
Three things live here: a dice roller, your campaign's homebrew rules, and the handouts you put in front of the table.

Who rolls

This table rolls its own dice, so out of the box **the tracker never rolls anything you did not ask it to**. Every check — concentration, a campaign mechanic, a random table — says **roll a die** and gives you a box to type the number into. It does the arithmetic from there and tells you the result.

Some tables would rather the screen did it. ⋮ → **Dice** → **let the tracker roll the dice** puts a **Roll** button beside every one of those boxes instead. Two things ignore the setting entirely, because they are dice tools rather than checks: the two **dice rollers**, and **Roll foe initiative**, which is always there.

The dice roller



The roller shows every die, and keeps the last sixteen rolls.

Type an expression: $1d20+5$, $2d8+1d6+4$, $4d6kh3$. **kh** and **kl** keep the highest or lowest N dice. The die buttons build the expression for you and **+1** / **-1** nudge the modifier.

The **advantage** / **disadvantage** selector rolls the whole expression twice and keeps the better or worse total — and shows you the one it dropped, so you can see how close it was.

Every die is shown individually: maximum faces go green, natural 1s on a d20 go red, and dice dropped by **kh** or **kl** are struck through. The log keeps the last sixteen rolls, which means "what did I actually roll for that" has an answer.

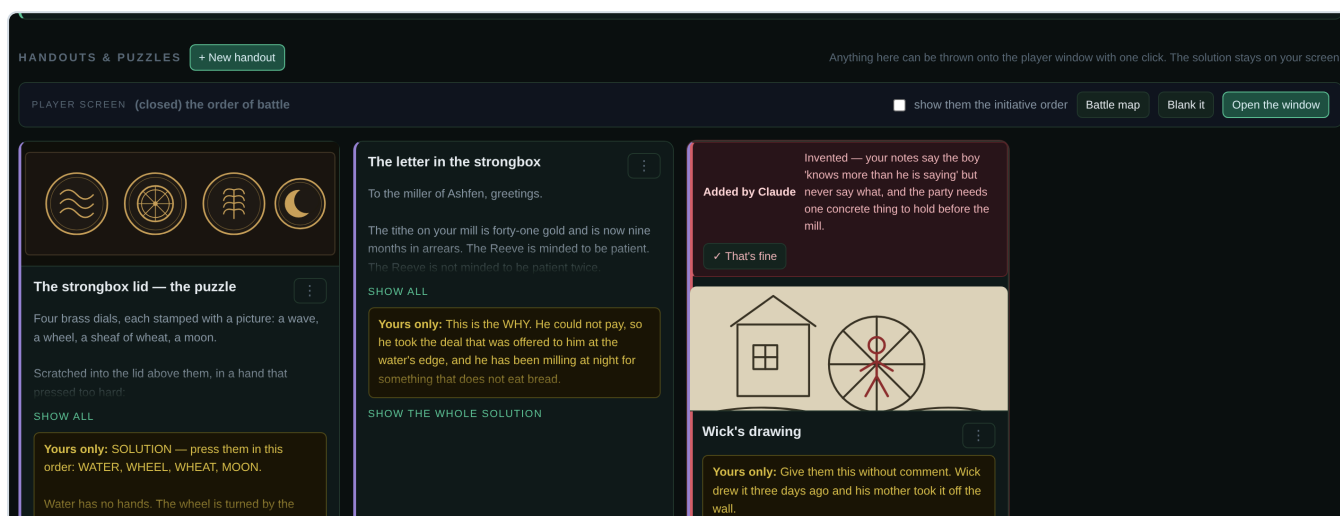
Campaign mechanics

The homebrew rule that makes your campaign yours — a curse, a madness track, corruption, heat, supply, a doom clock. Anything with tiers and a saving throw becomes:

- a one-line statement of the rule in a coloured callout,
- a **quick resolver** where you enter the situation and it prints the DC, how many saves, and what success and failure do, with a button to roll it,
- the full rules table,
- an optional random table with its own roll button,
- and free-text panels for the legitimate ways to cheat the rule.

You can have as many as you like. If your campaign has no such rule, leave the section empty.

Handouts and puzzles



Handouts: what the players read on top, the solution underneath, and one button to put it on their screen.

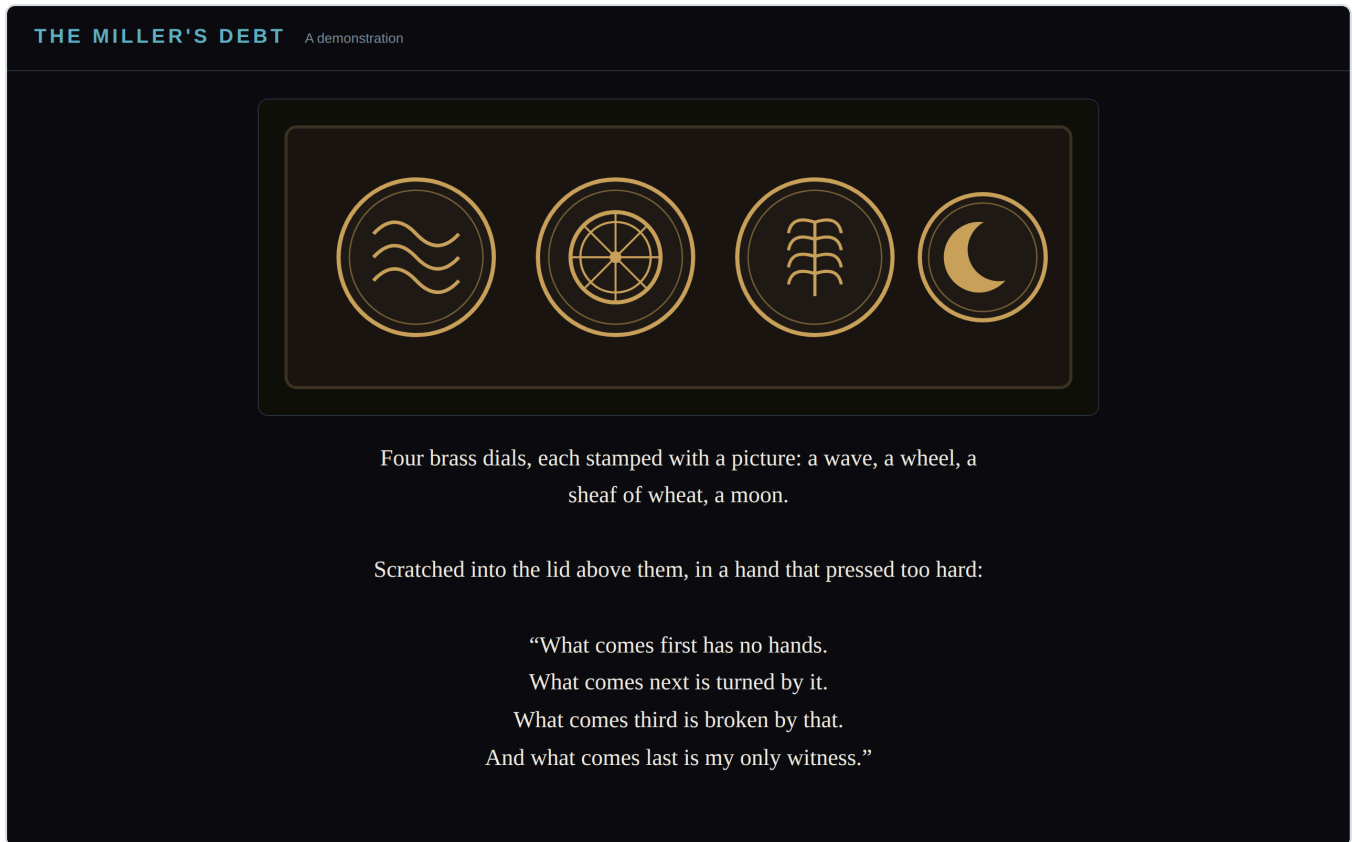
Each handout has a **player-facing side** — an image, some text, or both — and a **solution that never leaves your screen**. Write the riddle in the top half and the answer, the DCs and the consequences in the bottom half, and you can put the puzzle in front of the table while reading how it works off your own laptop. Long solutions expand in place; click *show the whole solution*.

Show to players throws it onto the second screen. The card turns green while it is up there.

10. THE PLAYERS' SCREEN

Players in the header opens a second browser window to drag onto your other monitor. Press it again to close it. Nothing about the main tracker changes whether it is open or not, so if you only have one screen you can ignore this entire section.

It shows exactly one thing at a time, and you choose which.



A handout, full screen. Image and text, nothing else.



A scene image from the Story tab.



Four brass dials, each stamped with a picture: a wave, a wheel, a sheaf of wheat, a moon.

Scratched into the lid above them, in a hand that pressed too hard:

“What comes first has no hands.
What comes next is turned by it.
What comes third is broken by that.
And what comes last is my only witness.”

The battle map, with the order of battle beside it — but only because it has been switched on.

The initiative order is hidden from them by default. There is a *show them the initiative order* tick in the Player screen bar at the top of the handouts section. Left off, they see the map and nothing else. Turned on, they see names, table numbers,

conditions and whose turn it is — and **never hit points, armour class or stat blocks**, whatever you do.

The fastest route mid-session is **Ctrl+K**: type a handout or image name, press Enter, and it is on their screen.

If nothing happens when you press Players, your browser has blocked the pop-up. Allow pop-ups for the page and press it again.

11. SETTING CLAUDE UP — ONCE

You need a place to keep the files so you are not attaching them again every time. On `claude.ai` that is a **Project**: a folder with its own instructions and its own documents, shared by every chat inside it.

Making it

1. Go to **claude.ai**, and in the left sidebar press **Projects** → **Create project**.
2. Name it something like **D&D — Table Aid**. The description can be one line: *turning my adventure notes into a Table Aid tracker*.
3. Open the project and find **Project knowledge** (on some layouts it is called *Add content* or a paperclip). This is the folder everything goes in.

What goes in the project knowledge

FILE	WHY IT LIVES HERE	REQUIRED
<code>02_BUILD_SPEC.md</code>	The contract. Every field the tracker understands and the rules about what Claude may and may not touch. This is the one that does the work.	Yes
<code>01_AUTHORIZING_GUIDE.md</code>	What the tool actually does, so Claude answers your questions about it correctly	Recommended
<code>03_ADVENTURE_TEMPLATE.md</code>	The fill-in form, if you would rather write into headings than face a blank page	Optional
<code>05_DEMO_SOURCE_NOTES.md</code>	A worked example of good notes. Useful for Claude to see the standard you are aiming at	Optional
Your adventure	Add it as a document once it is written, or just paste it into the chat	Either

Do **not** put the tracker's `.html` file in the project. It is a quarter of a megabyte of code that Claude never needs to read — the build travels as a small block of JSON instead.

Project instructions — do not skip this

Open **Project instructions** (or *Custom instructions*) and paste the block below.

It is not just a convenience. Project instructions are **always in front of Claude**, whatever else is going on, whereas a document in the project can end up being searched rather than read (see *When projects get full*, below). So the rules that must never be missed live here, and the field-by-field detail lives in the spec, where being read in pieces is survivable.

When I ask you to build or update a Table Aid tracker:

1. Read 02_BUILD_SPEC.md in full first. If you cannot see it, say so and stop.
2. KEEP MY WORDS. Anything I wrote goes in exactly as I wrote it – don't tidy, rename, reorder or improve it.
3. MARK EVERYTHING YOU ADD. Every creature, encounter, segment, mechanic and handout you invent, stat, scale, balance or guess at gets:
"ai": true, "aiOk": false,
"aiNote": "<one sentence: what you did and why>"
Anything from my own text carries no mark. Unmarked invention is the worst outcome; marking my own writing is the second worst.
4. Return ONE fenced json block containing {"tableAidBuild":1,"data":{...}} and nothing else inside it. Questions and reasoning go outside it.
5. Ask me about anything where guessing wrong changes my story – the ending, who the villain is, whether a fight is winnable. Build everything else.

My table: 4 players, D&D 2024 rules. I roll physical dice.

Change the last line to match your table. That is the whole setup, and you only do it once.

When projects get full

Claude reads everything in a project's knowledge directly — until the project gets big. At that point it switches automatically to **searching** the documents instead of reading them whole, and **you cannot turn that off**.

For a reference document that is fine. For a *contract* like the build spec it is not: Claude may pull the parts about field names and miss the parts about provenance, and nothing will look wrong.

The authoring pack is small — about eleven thousand tokens all together — so it will never trigger this on its own. What triggers it is everything else you put beside it. So:

- **Keep this project for Table Aid only.** Campaign bibles, session logs, module PDFs and rules references go in a *different* project. They will make your builds worse here, not better.
- **If you suspect the spec didn't land,** ask before you build: *"Before you build anything — what are the three provenance fields, and what does each one mean?"* If the answer isn't `ai`, `aiOk` and `aiNote`, paste the spec straight into the chat and carry on.

The skill instead. If you would rather not manage a project at all, `table-aid.skill` is the same contract packaged as a Claude skill. Install it once in your account and say *"build this into a Table Aid tracker"* in any chat, with nothing attached.

12. FROM YOUR NOTES TO THE TRACKER

Start a new chat inside the project, paste the prompt, paste your adventure underneath.

The short version of the prompt

Build my adventure into a Table Aid tracker, following 02_BUILD_SPEC.md.

My party: 4 players, level 3, D&D 2024, no magic items

Session length: about 2 hours

Tone: damp English folk horror, warm rather than grim

My adventure follows.

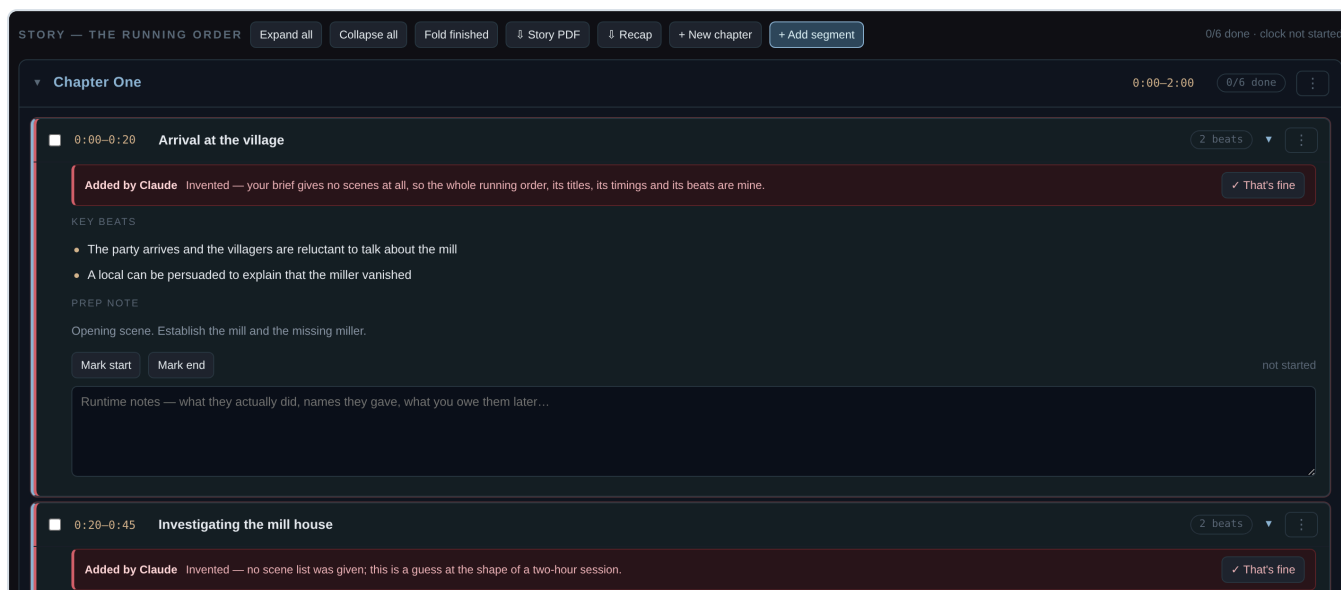
Claude returns one fenced block of JSON. Copy it, then in the tracker: **⋮ top right** → **Paste a build from Claude**, and choose **Replace everything** or **Merge into what I have**. Merging keeps your campaign and folds the new material in; a creature whose name you already have is kept as yours rather than overwritten.

How much you write is how much you get

This is the part worth understanding before you start, because it changes what comes back more than anything else you can do.

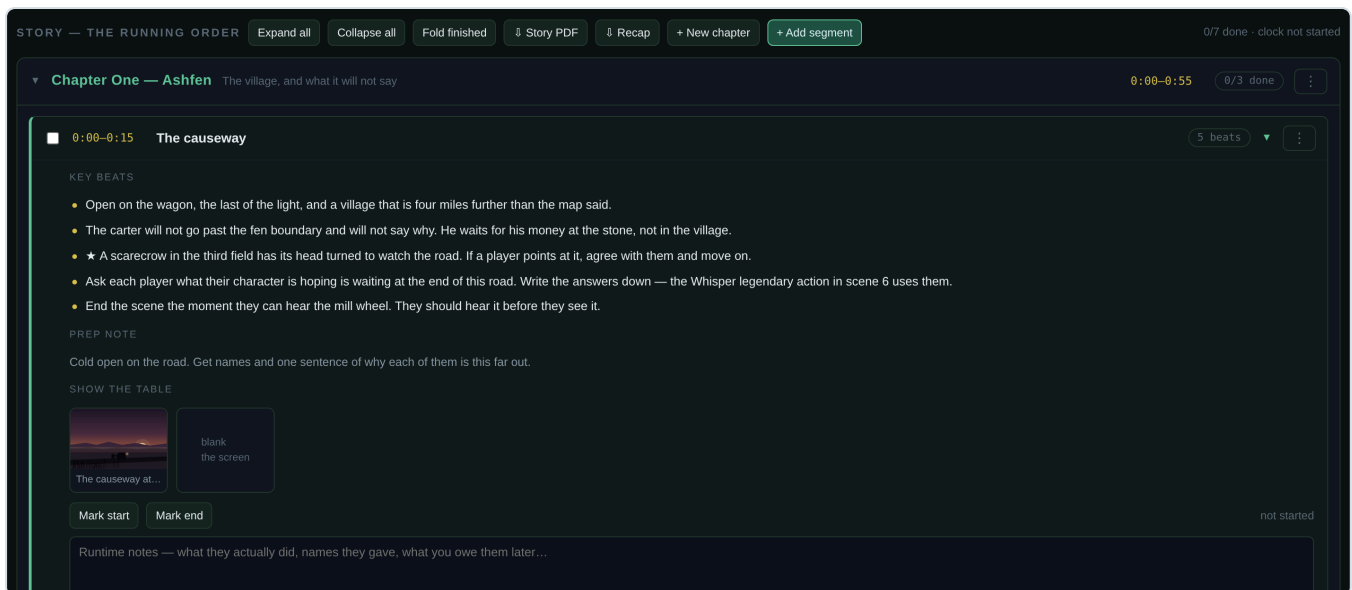
The two-sentence brief. Somebody writes: *"A haunted watermill. Four players, level 3, about two hours. There's a hag."*

Claude can build a running tracker from that — but every single thing in it is a guess, and it says so:



Eleven items, eleven red marks. Nothing here came from the author.

The same adventure, written properly. A page of notes — seven scenes with rough times, four creatures with numbers, a homebrew rule, a puzzle with its answer, and an honest list of what the author hadn't decided. Same tool, same prompt:



Four marks in the whole build. Everything else is the author's, untouched.

	TWO SENTENCES	A PAGE OF NOTES
Items in the build	11	24
Marked as invented	11 of 11	4 of 24
Creatures	3, all invented	6, one invented
Scene beats	all invented	all the author's
The ending	a placeholder	the author's
Puzzle with a solution	none	one, with three tiers of hint
Time to review	the whole file	about four minutes

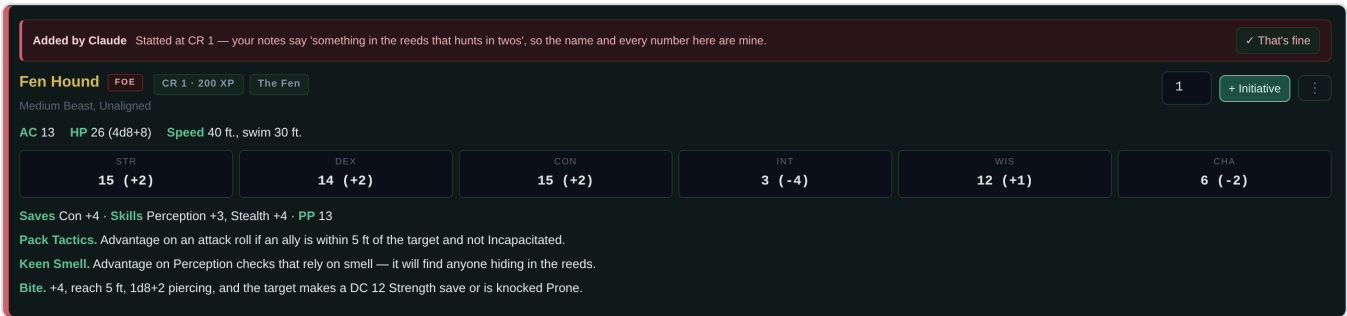
The point is not that the thin build is bad. It runs, it is balanced, and for a pick-up game on a Tuesday it is genuinely enough. The point is that **you cannot tell which parts are yours, because none of them are** — and a session made entirely of a model's guesses is a session where nothing surprises you either.

What is worth writing down, in order of how much it buys you:

1. **What actually happens in each scene.** Three fragments per scene beats three paragraphs of prose. This is the single highest-value thing you can write.
2. **How your fights are meant to be won.** "The grate drains the room and stops its regeneration" is the difference between a fight and a slog.
3. **Constitution saves** on anything that concentrates.
4. **Your ending.** Claude will write you one, and it will be competent, and it will not be yours.
5. **What you haven't decided.** List it. Claude asks about those instead of quietly inventing them, which is exactly the trade you want.

13. CHECKING CLAUDE'S WORK

Every creature, encounter, segment, mechanic and handout that **Claude invented** carries a red rail, a one-sentence note saying what it did and why, and a ✓ **That's fine** button. Everything **you** wrote renders plain.



Everything Claude invented carries a red rail and a sentence explaining itself.

The review walk

The header pill says how many are still unreviewed. **Click it and it takes you to the next one** — switching tab, opening the right chapter, scrolling to the card and highlighting it. Click again for the one after that. You never have to hunt.



Clicking the pill walks you through the file, one unreviewed item at a time.

Read the note, and then either press ✓ **That's fine**, or make the change yourself, or write it down for the next round (§14). In the demonstration file, all four take about four minutes.

⋮ → **What Claude added** has the same walk as a button, plus *Accept everything*, *Flag it all again*, and a switch that hides every mark at once. Turn it off and you have a clean tracker; turn it back on any time, even mid-session.

The notes are meant to be argued with. "Statted at CR 5 — you named them and said 'tough but not elite', so every number here is mine" is an invitation to change the numbers, not a disclaimer.

14. ASKING FOR CHANGES

You will not like everything. That is the expected outcome, not a failure — and there are three ways to say so, in ascending order of effort.

1. Just tell it

Go back to the same chat and say what is wrong in plain words. The adventure is still in the conversation, so you do not need to re-explain anything:

The Fen Hound isn't right — they should be birds, not dogs, and they should grapple and lift rather than knock down. Rebuild that creature and both fights it appears in, and give me the whole data object back with the marks intact.

Always ask for **the whole data object back**, and paste it in with **Replace everything**. Asking for a fragment gets you a fragment you then have to splice by hand.

2. Mark up the story

Story → **↓ Story PDF** gives you the whole adventure as a document. Read it on a train, on paper, anywhere that is not the tab you built it in — you will spot things you never noticed on screen. Then tell Claude which bits to change.

3. Mark it up in Word

Ask for the review copy:

Give me the story as a Word document with a comment on everything you invented, so I can mark it up and hand it back.

You get a **.docx** where each invented passage carries a comment explaining itself, anchored to the exact text:

The screenshot shows a Word document with a review copy. The document text includes a section titled "FIGHT: the drowned wheel" with a list of bullet points. To the right of the text, there are two comment boxes. The first comment box is anchored to the first bullet point and contains the text: "Added by Claude. Your outline gives this fight one line — 'the pond ones come out'. Everything under this heading (who comes out of the water, what they want, Halloway's moment, the apron with the wrong name on it) is mine. If any of it isn't your fight, say so here and it goes. Claude 08/15/2026 08:06". The second comment box is anchored to the "Battle map" text and contains the text: "Added by Claude. Guessed from 'the mill yard, the pond on one side, a cart to hide behind'. The two stairs out of the pond, the well and the exact dimensions are invented. Describe the yard properly here and I'll redraw it. Claude 08/15/2026 08:06".

1:15 — 1:35

FIGHT: the drowned wheel

- They come up out of the water without a sound. The first anyone knows is the cold.
- ★ If Sister Halloway is with them, this is her scene — Turn Undead, and she is visibly terrified while she does it.
- The millers try to grapple and drag toward the water, not to kill. Being pulled in starts the Damp clock.
- One of the millers is wearing an apron with a name stitched into it, and it is not the missing man's name. There were others.
- Keep Wick out of it. He hides, and he watches, and he does not run.

Prep note. Two millers out of the pond, two hounds from the yard gate. Halloway's Turn Undead is the moment here.

The fight: The drowned wheel — The mill yard · first hour of the night
2× Drowned Miller · 2× Fen Hound

Battle map: The mill yard — 16 × 12 squares · 80 ft × 60 ft

Two of them come up out of the millpond and one is already behind the party, in the water butt by the gate. Sister Halloway's Turn Undead lands here if she has followed them out.

Added by Claude. Your outline gives this fight one line — 'the pond ones come out'. Everything under this heading (who comes out of the water, what they want, Halloway's moment, the apron with the wrong name on it) is mine. If any of it isn't your fight, say so here and it goes.
Claude
08/15/2026 08:06

Added by Claude. Guessed from 'the mill yard, the pond on one side, a cart to hide behind'. The two stairs out of the pond, the well and the exact dimensions are invented. Describe the yard properly here and I'll redraw it.
Claude
08/15/2026 08:06

The review copy: comments in the margin, anchored to the passage they are about.

Reply to the comments with what you actually want. Or turn on **Review** → **Track Changes** and rewrite the text directly, striking out anything that should go. Or highlight a paragraph and type **WRONG** next to it — precision is not required.

Then hand the file back:

I've marked up the story – apply my comments and give me an updated build.

You get a fresh JSON block with your changes made, the marks cleared on anything you accepted, and new marks on anything your change forced Claude to invent in turn. Paste it in with **Replace everything** and the tracker is up to date.

Save first. *Replace everything* replaces your whole campaign. The pill beside **Load** tells you how long it has been since you saved, and **Ctrl+Z** will undo the paste if you forget.

15. SAVING, UNDO AND BACKUPS

There is **no autosave**. Browser storage is not available to a file opened this way, and pretending otherwise would be worse than saying so.

- **Save** downloads one JSON holding every tab, your runtime notes, the scene stamps and the clock. Keep it next to the HTML file, or in whatever cloud drive you already use.
 - **The pill** beside Load tells you how long it has been. It goes amber at five minutes and red at fifteen, and the browser will stop you closing the tab with unsaved changes.
 - **Undo** — Ctrl+Z, the header button, or the Undo that appears on the toast right after anything destructive. Twenty steps deep, covering deletes, clears, damage, rests, loads and merges. It does not undo typing in a notes box, and it never rolls back the session clock.
 - **Automatic backups** are off by default. Turn them on in **⋮** → **Not losing your evening** and it writes a timestamped JSON to your downloads every 10, 15 or 30 minutes. The first one makes the browser ask whether to allow multiple downloads; say yes once and it stops asking.
-

16. KEYBOARD

KEY	WHAT IT DOES
Space	Next turn
R	Open the quick dice roller with a d20 loaded
A	Area damage
P	Open or close the player window
Ctrl+K	Jump to anything — creatures, fights, segments, mechanics, conditions, spells, anyone in the current initiative order, handouts and scene images
Ctrl+Z	Undo
Click the review pill	Jump to the next thing Claude added that you have not signed off
Enter in a damage box	Damage
Shift+Enter in a damage box	Heal
Esc	Close whatever is open

17. THINGS THAT WILL BITE YOU

- **Save before you close the tab.** It is the only thing standing between you and a lost evening.
- **Pasting a build with *Replace everything* replaces the whole campaign.** Save first, or use *Merge*.
- **Map rows must all be the same length,** or the grid will look wrong.
- **Every creature needs a Constitution save value,** or its concentration checks default to +0.
- **XP is per creature, not per encounter.**
- **The app assumes a laptop.** It works on a tablet in landscape. It is not a phone tool. Ctrl+scroll zooms if you are reading it from across the table.
- **The player window is a pop-up,** and **Firefox blocks pop-ups by default.** The first time you press **Players** you may get a bar across the top of the page instead of a window: allow pop-ups for the page and press it again.
- **Uploaded images live inside the save file.** A handful is fine. Forty is a large JSON.
- **Ask for the whole `data` object** when you request changes, not a fragment.
- **Don't let the Claude project fill up.** Keep it to the authoring pack and your current adventure; once a project outgrows the context window, Claude searches its documents instead of reading them, and the build spec is the wrong kind of document to read in fragments.
- **The Story PDF uses your browser's print dialog.** Pick the PDF destination, not a printer — *Save as PDF* in Chrome and Edge, *Save to PDF* in Firefox.

APPENDIX A — MAP TILES

One character per 5-foot square, in the encounter editor's grid box.

CHARACTER	SQUARE
#	rock or wall
.	floor
~	open air, water, or a fall
^	rubble — difficult terrain
S	stair or ramp
=	ledge edge
O	pillar or post
T	plinth
C	chimney going up
X	crack going down
D	door

Tokens are one per line: `x | y | letter | side | name`, where `x` and `y` count from zero at the top left and `side` is `foe`, `ally` or `pc`. Keep maps to roughly 20 × 14 squares; larger ones stop being copyable onto a mat.

APPENDIX B — EDITOR SYNTAX

Every one of these fields has a **library** button beside it with common entries to click in and a fuller explanation.

FIELD	FORMAT
Traits and actions	One per line. Plain HTML is allowed; wrap the label in <code>...</code> .
Spells	<code>name \ level \ perDay \ casting note \ effect</code> — level 0 is a cantrip, and a number in perDay makes it innate instead of spending a slot.
Limited uses	<code>name \ max \ recharge \ note</code>
Triggers	<code>name \ kind \ healAmount \ text</code> , where kind is <code>auto</code> (gets an Apply button), <code>roll</code> , or <code>rem</code> for a reminder.
Mechanic table	Pipe-separated, headers on the first line. Then tell it which column holds the DC.
Key beats	One per line.
Times	<code>h:mm</code> from the start of the session.

Table Aid is an unofficial fan tool with no affiliation to Wizards of the Coast. It reproduces no official stat blocks, spell text or rules text — everything in it is written fresh and mechanically equivalent. Bring your own Player's Handbook.